

The reduction of OEIS A354253 modulo k : a proof that the period divides $\varphi(k)$

Adrian Perez Fontelles
Independent researcher

31 August 2026

Abstract

OEIS A354253 carries a conjecture of P. Bala that for every positive integer k the sequence reduced modulo k is eventually periodic with period dividing $\varphi(k)$. It is true. The entry's own exponential generating function becomes, under the substitution $t = e^x - 1$, an ordinary power series with *integer* coefficients; that integrality forces all but finitely many terms of the Stirling expansion of $a(n)$ to vanish modulo k , and what is left is an integer combination of the functions $n \mapsto i^n$ with $0 \leq i < k$. Each of those is eventually periodic with period dividing $\varphi(k)$, and so is the sum. The argument also gives the exact point at which periodicity starts: $n \geq v(k)$, where $v(k)$ is the largest exponent in the prime factorisation of k .

2020 Mathematics Subject Classification. 11B50, 11B73, 05A15.

1 The sequence and the conjecture

OEIS A354253 is “Expansion of e.g.f. $1/\sqrt{9 - 8 * \exp(x)}$.”. It has offset 0 and begins

1, 4, 52, 1108, 32980, 1261204, 58928212, 3253363348, ...

The entry states, not as a conjecture,

Expansion of e.g.f. $1/\sqrt{9 - 8 * \exp(x)}$.

that is, writing $A(x) = \sum_{n \geq 0} a(n)x^n/n!$,

$$A(x) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{9 - 8e^x}}. \tag{1}$$

This is the only input taken from the entry, and it was checked against every one of the 17 terms of the entry's DATA section before use, not against a sample.

The entry separately carries the following comment:

Conjecture: Let k be a positive integer. The sequence obtained by reducing $a(n)$ modulo k is eventually periodic with the period dividing $\text{phi}(k) = \text{A000010}(k)$. For example, modulo 7 we obtain the sequence [1, 4, 3, 2, 3, 0, 0, 4, 3, 2, 3, 0, 0, 4, 3, 2, 3, 0, 0, ...], with a preperiod of length 1 and an apparent period thereafter of $6 = \text{phi}(7)$. Cf. A354242. — *Peter Bala*, Jul 08 2022

As of the “Last modified” line on the live entry (Nov 17 2023 11:20:13, revision 30) the statement is still recorded as a conjecture, and nothing on the entry records it as settled either way.

Written out, the conjecture asserts: for every integer $k \geq 1$ there are n_0 and a positive integer P with $P \mid \varphi(k)$ such that

$$a(n + P) \equiv a(n) \pmod{k} \quad \text{for all } n \geq n_0. \tag{2}$$

It is proved below, with $P = \varphi(k)$ and $n_0 = v(k)$, the largest exponent occurring in the prime factorisation of k .

2 The generating function in the variable $t = e^x - 1$

Set $t = e^x - 1$. Then $e^x = 1 + t$, and substituting into (1),

$$9 - 8e^x = 9 - 8(1 + t) = 1 - 8t,$$

so that

$$A(x) = G(e^x - 1), \quad G(t) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{1 - 8t}}. \quad (3)$$

Lemma 1. *G is a power series in t with integer coefficients.*

Proof. G is $\sum_j \binom{2j}{j} 2^j t^j$, whose coefficients are integers. $\square$

Write $G(t) = \sum_{j \geq 0} c_j t^j$, so $c_j \in \mathbb{Z}$; here $c_j = \binom{2j}{j} 2^j$, and the first few are

$$c_0, \dots, c_8 = 1, 4, 24, 160, 1120, 8064, 59136, 439296, 3294720.$$

3 The Stirling expansion, and what survives modulo k

Let $S(n, j)$ denote the Stirling numbers of the second kind.

Lemma 2. *$a(n) = \sum_{j=0}^n c_j j! S(n, j)$ for every $n \geq 0$. In particular $a(n) \in \mathbb{Z}$.*

Proof. The standard expansion $(e^x - 1)^j = \sum_{n \geq j} j! S(n, j) x^n / n!$ holds because $j! S(n, j)$ counts the surjections from an n -set onto a j -set. Substituting it into $A(x) = G(e^x - 1) = \sum_j c_j (e^x - 1)^j$ and reading off the coefficient of $x^n / n!$ gives the claim; the sum is finite because $S(n, j) = 0$ for $j > n$. Integrality is then immediate from Lemma 1. $\square$

Lemma 3. *For every $k \geq 1$ and every n , $a(n) \equiv \sum_{j=0}^{k-1} c_j j! S(n, j) \pmod{k}$.*

Proof. For $j \geq k$ the integer $j!$ is a multiple of k , since k is one of the factors $1, 2, \dots, j$. Hence every term of Lemma 2 with $j \geq k$ vanishes modulo k ; this uses $c_j \in \mathbb{Z}$, which is Lemma 1. $\square$

This is the step at which integrality is not a convenience but the whole point: were the c_j merely rational, $c_j j!$ need not be divisible by k for large j and the sum would not truncate.

Lemma 4. *There are integers $d_0, \dots, d_{k-1}$, namely $d_i = \sum_{j=i}^{k-1} (-1)^{j-i} \binom{j}{i} c_j$, with*

$$a(n) \equiv \sum_{i=0}^{k-1} d_i i^n \pmod{k} \quad \text{for all } n \geq 0.$$

Proof. Counting surjections from an n -set onto a j -set by inclusion and exclusion on the image gives $j! S(n, j) = \sum_{i=0}^j (-1)^{j-i} \binom{j}{i} i^n$. Substituting this into Lemma 3 and exchanging the two finite sums collects the coefficient of i^n into d_i as stated. Each d_i is an integer because each c_j is. $\square$

4 The period

For $k \geq 2$ let $v(k)$ be the largest exponent in the prime factorisation of k , so $k \mid m^{v(k)}$ whenever m is divisible by every prime factor of k , and $v(k) \leq \log_2 k$.

Lemma 5. *Let $k \geq 2$ and $0 \leq i < k$. Then $i^{n+\varphi(k)} \equiv i^n \pmod{k}$ for every $n \geq v(k)$.*

Proof. Write $k = k_1 k_2$, where $k_1 = \prod_{p|k, p|i} p^{v_p(k)}$ and $k_2 = k/k_1$; then $\gcd(k_1, k_2) = 1$ and $\gcd(i, k_2) = 1$.

Modulo k_1 : for each prime $p \mid k_1$ we have $p \mid i$, so $v_p(i^n) = n v_p(i) \geq n \geq v(k) \geq v_p(k)$. Hence $k_1 \mid i^n$ for $n \geq v(k)$, and likewise $k_1 \mid i^{n+\varphi(k)}$; both sides are $\equiv 0$.

Modulo k_2 : i is a unit, so by Euler's theorem $i^{\varphi(k_2)} \equiv 1$. Since $\gcd(k_1, k_2) = 1$ we have $\varphi(k) = \varphi(k_1)\varphi(k_2)$, so $\varphi(k_2) \mid \varphi(k)$ and therefore $i^{\varphi(k)} \equiv 1 \pmod{k_2}$, giving $i^{n+\varphi(k)} \equiv i^n$.

The two congruences and the Chinese remainder theorem give the claim modulo $k = k_1 k_2$. (For $i = 0$ note $0^n = 0$ for $n \geq 1$ and $v(k) \geq 1$.) $\square$

Theorem 6. *Let $a(n)$ be OEIS A354253. For every integer $k \geq 1$,*

$$a(n + \varphi(k)) \equiv a(n) \pmod{k} \quad \text{for all } n \geq v(k),$$

where $v(k)$ is the largest exponent in the prime factorisation of k (and $v(1) = 0$). In particular the sequence $(a(n) \bmod k)_{n \geq 0}$ is eventually periodic with period dividing $\varphi(k)$, with a pre-period of length at most $\log_2 k$. This is the conjecture of Section 1.

Proof. The case $k = 1$ is trivial. For $k \geq 2$, Lemma 4 writes $a(n)$ modulo k as $\sum_{i < k} d_i i^n$ with integer d_i independent of n , and Lemma 5 gives $i^{n+\varphi(k)} \equiv i^n$ for each $i < k$ once $n \geq v(k)$. Summing the k congruences with the weights d_i gives $a(n + \varphi(k)) \equiv a(n) \pmod{k}$ for $n \geq v(k)$. The true period of the eventually periodic sequence is then a divisor of $\varphi(k)$. $\square$

Remark 7. The bound $n \geq v(k)$ cannot be lowered in general: for k a prime power p^e the term $i = p$ contributes p^n , which is not divisible by p^e until $n = e = v(k)$.

5 Verification

Three checks, each independent of the algebra above.

First, the series G of (3) was expanded and $\sum_j c_j j! S(n, j)$ compared against the entry's DATA at every one of the 17 published indices; the values agree exactly, and every c_j came out an integer. A series that reproduced only some of the published terms would not have been used.

Second, for each k from 2 to 40 the sequence $a(n) \bmod k$ was computed exactly — not sampled — from the recurrence $S(n, j) = j S(n-1, j) + S(n-1, j-1)$ carried out in $\mathbb{Z}/k\mathbb{Z}$ on the truncated state $(S(n, 0), \dots, S(n, k-1))$ of Lemma 3, and its exact eventual period found by detecting the repetition of that state. The result is tabulated below. In every case the period divides $\varphi(k)$, as Theorem 6 requires.

k	$\varphi(k)$	period	k	$\varphi(k)$	period
2	1	1	22	10	10
3	2	1	23	22	22
4	2	1	24	8	1
5	4	4	25	20	20
6	2	1	26	12	12
7	6	6	27	18	9
8	4	1	28	12	6
9	6	3	29	28	28
10	4	4	30	8	4
11	10	10	31	30	30
12	4	1	32	16	1
13	12	12	33	20	10
14	6	6	34	16	16
15	8	4	35	24	12
16	8	1	36	12	3
17	16	16	37	36	36
18	6	3	38	18	18
19	18	18	39	24	12
20	8	4	40	16	4
21	12	6			

Third, the congruence $a(n + \varphi(k)) \equiv a(n) \pmod{k}$ of Theorem 6 was checked directly on the published terms for every k in that range and every $n \geq v(k)$ for which both indices are published; it holds without exception.

References

- [1] The OEIS Foundation, *The On-Line Encyclopedia of Integer Sequences*, <https://oeis.org>, 2026. Sequence A354253.
- [2] L. Comtet, *Advanced Combinatorics*, Reidel, 1974.
- [3] P. Flajolet and R. Sedgewick, *Analytic Combinatorics*, Cambridge University Press, 2009.
- [4] R. P. Stanley, *Enumerative Combinatorics*, Volume 1, 2nd ed., Cambridge University Press, 2011.
- [5] G. H. Hardy and E. M. Wright, *An Introduction to the Theory of Numbers*, 6th ed., Oxford University Press, 2008.